> *influenced by the limitations of our partners*, or diverted by difficulties of the day.[5]
>
> *(emphasis added)*

The exact contours of these components, particularly a sense of positive unilateralism underlined in this statement, unfolded gradually as the policy was put in practice.

Modi's "neighbourhood first" initiative promised more than the neighbour-hood approach of his predecessors for three reasons. One was the electoral mandate that gave him a freer hand and greater force in the conduct of foreign policy. Given the clear majority enjoyed by the BJP in parliament, he did not have to depend upon allies. He had also won the election on his own through a massive campaign woven around his persona. He was not an "accidental prime minister," as Manmohan Singh was described by his own former media advisor.[6] Modi had made himself known for dynamism and energy since his Gujarat days and was keen to put his personal stamp, different from the Nehruvian legacy, on the style of governance, including in the conduct of foreign policy. Second, there was also a creeping perception in the neighbourhood that India was not paying enough attention to the smaller neighbours. There have been very few Prime Minister–level visits to the neighbours, and India needed to do much more in terms of participating in their development programmes, as mentioned earlier.

Last but not least was the factor of China's emergence and assertiveness that had started impinging on India's immediate neighbourhood. Earlier, China generally came in as a South Asian player on demand by India's immediate neigh-bours, mostly to counter their discomfort with India. Over more than the past couple of decades or so, however, China had been developing its own strategic agenda to be economically and strategically present in the region irrespective of the preference or efforts of India and/or its neighbours.[7] During the late 1990s, China had moved the